society accommodations were perfectly organized. Apart from beds, temporary toilets and bathrooms, the Congress team under Utkarsha Rupwate had even organized volunteers to run a cloakroom service (so we could deposit our bags for the day's yatra and collect them again in the evening, after it was over). To do so for tens of thousands of people was no small feat. The operation was so smooth that it began to raise doubts about whether every other aspect of the Yatra was also preplanned! I distinctly recall that senior journalists such as Nikhil Wagle and Hemant Karnik voiced these doubts when I met them in Deglur. But like all of us, they were astonished at how effectively the Congress organization was functioning. Was this the same party that the BJP had said would be finished? Which was trounced so badly in two general elections?

We were all pleasantly surprised at how effectively the Yatra was functioning. That pleasure was magnified many times over by the overwhelming response by ordinary people, who stood outside their homes, at roadside dhabas and by the wayside to welcome the Yatra. One had to be there to truly understand this profoundly moving experience. Some people sketched rangolis in front of their houses; others offered aartis (ritual prayers) to not just Rahul, but also the other yatris; yet others showered us with flowers. Adivasi tribes such as the Gond, Pawra, Warli and Phase Paradhi danced in their traditional attire along the route. Schoolchildren even bunked school to perform dhol-lezim at multiple places. The devout stood by the wayside, holding the taal mrudung and chanting '*Dnyanoba Mauli Tukaram*'. At another place, people followed Basavanna, the twelfth-century philosopher elaborating on democracy at Anubhava Mantapa in Karnataka (the first religious parliament in the world). Separately, people were re-enacting the Pandharpur Wari pilgrimage by moving along with the Yatra, singing the abhangs by saint-poets. Yet others (mostly schoolchildren) were just standing with hand-drawn placards. I recall one child holding a placard that read: 'Rahul ji, you are walking for our bright future.' Similarly, a young girl had climbed atop a high post, holding a photograph of Babasaheb Ambedkar, excitedly waving at the yatris. It was